Google Maps helps you find the best route to a particular destination. Google has developed a few other services such as Street View and Expeditions as well. In this chapter, we will explore the features and usage of Google's various Geo Service tools, including a short glimpse at possible competitors.

Google Earth

Keyhole Inc developed EarthViewer 3D in 2001. The company was funded by CIA partners In-Q-Tel, the National Geospatial Intelligence Agency, and Sony and Nvidia. In 2004, Google acquired Keyhole and renamed the geographical tool to Earth. The tool superimposes images sourced from satellite imagery, the geographic information system (GIS) and aerial photography.

When Google Earth was launched, it sourced images from the Landsat 7 satellite. However, the tool suffered a serious blow when the satellite malfunctioned. Google took advantage of data mining in 2013 to rectify the problem. By combining multiple images captured via Landsat 7, Google Earth eliminated diagonal gaps and clouds in the rendered images. With the launch of Landsat 8, image sharpness and clearness was enhanced.

The resolution of images produced by Google Earth ranges from 15 meters to 15 centimetres. Even though a majority of the images are shown in 2D, 3D renders are available for metro cities. For example, if you search for Airports, you will be able to view images of flights and the runway. Google Earth also make use of digital elevation model (DEM) data fetched by the Shuttle Radar Topography Mission (SRTM) of NASA.

With Google Earth, you can explore various places around the globe in a digital format from the comfort of your own homes, using a PC, Android

Google Earth helps you to dissect locations clearly via satellite images